PROGRESS

Southern Africa: monthly update, September – October 2026

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> *Developments reported in sources published between the beginning of last month and today, grouped by story, oldest first.*

INSTITUTIONS AND MANDATES · INSTRUMENTS AND HARMONISATION · SHARED SYSTEMS AND INFRASTRUCTURE · COORDINATION AND COLLABORATION · CAPACITY AND INCLUSION

Institutions and mandates

Regional collaboration

Regional collaboration

REGIONAL HIGHER EDUCATION DATA SYSTEM

- **SADC must build its own knowledge to drive industrialisation, says Manamela** — SAnews (South African Government News Agency), 1 September 2026 SOUTH AFRICA

  South Africa's higher education minister, Buti Manamela, told a meeting of SADC university vice-chancellors in Johannesburg on 31 August 2026 that the region must build its own computing capacity, datasets, African-language technologies and cybersecurity. He set five priorities, including agreement on a regional higher education data system, to show results by the SADC ministers' meeting in June 2027.

- **Universities should turn regional cooperation into action** — University of the Witwatersrand, 1 September 2026 SOUTH AFRICA

  University leaders, government representatives, the SADC Secretariat and the Southern African Regional Universities Association met at Wits University on 31 August–1 September 2026. They discussed the SADC higher education strategy, a proposed SADC University of Transformation, a regional higher education data system and micro-credentials. No design, cost or timetable for the data system is given.

CRASA (COMMUNICATIONS REGULATORS ASSOCIATION OF SOUTHERN AFRICA)

- **CRASA Committee for the 2026/27 Financial Year Meets in Gaborone, 2-4 September** — Communications Regulators' Association of Southern Africa (CRASA), 2 September 2026

  The Communications Regulators' Association of Southern Africa held the first in-person meeting of a committee for its 2026/27 financial year in Gaborone, Botswana, from 2 to 4 September 2026. The meeting was convened to advance the committee's 2026/27 workplan; no agenda items or outcomes are given.

- **46th Ordinary Meeting of the CRASA Executive Committee (EXCO)** — CRASA, 16 September 2026 MALAWI

The Communications Regulators' Association of Southern Africa held the 46th ordinary meeting of its Executive Committee on 14–16 September 2026 at Makokola Club, Mangochi, hosted by the Malawi Communications Regulatory Authority. The meeting had been rescheduled because of venue availability. The listing gives no outcomes.

PROMOTION OF REGIONAL CAPITAL-MARKET INTEGRATION

- **SADC positions Southern Africa as an Integrated Investment destination at AIM Congress 2026** — Southern African Development Community (SADC), 9 September 2026

  The Southern African Development Community and the Committee of SADC Stock Exchanges attended AIM Congress 2026 in Dubai from 7 to 9 September, promoting Southern Africa as an integrated investment destination. A joint investment forum presented regional capital-market integration as a way to finance infrastructure, industrialisation and energy. No deals or sums are reported.

SADCOPAC RESOLUTIONS ON OVERSIGHT OF DIGITAL SYSTEMS

- **SADC PACs sub committees examine 3 dimensions of future public accountability** — Eswatini Positive News, 15 September 2026 ESWATINI

  A commission of the SADC public accounts committees' 18th annual conference in Eswatini reported that governments may see spending data almost in real time while parliamentary oversight can come 12 to 24 months later. It considered using data analytics and AI to screen transactions for auditors, with secure oversight access to financial systems, and warned against treating technology as a substitute for human judgement.

- **SADCOPAC turns oversight into action with 32 resolutions** — Eswatini Positive News, 16 September 2026

  Public accounts committees across SADC adopted 32 resolutions in Eswatini on 16 September 2026, committing each to map major digital transformation projects and review at least one digital system for value for money within 12 months. Oversight is to extend to e-government, digital identity, e-procurement and e-payment systems.

IDEA PROGRAMME (INCLUSIVE DIGITALIZATION IN EASTERN AND SOUTHERN AFRICA)

- **IDEA Half-Year Implementation Progress Report: January-June 2026 and Outlook for July-December 2026** — COMESA Secretariat (IDEA project), 1 October 2026 ANGOLA DRC MALAWI ZAMBIA ESWATINI EAST AFRICA

  COMESA's half-year progress report on the World Bank-financed Inclusive Digitalisation in Eastern and Southern Africa programme, a US$2.48 billion envelope, covers January to June 2026 in Angola, the DRC, Malawi, Zambia and Eswatini. The COMESA secretariat had spent 9% of its US$3.71 million 2026 budget by June, and moved its AI and regional digital inclusion consultancies from procurement to implementation.

Instruments and harmonisation

AI

AI

COMESA REGIONAL AI STRATEGY

- **AI can drive economic growth across COMESA region - COMESA director** — Eswatini Positive News, 16 September 2026 EAST AFRICA

A COMESA official told the regional AI validation meeting in Eswatini that AI could improve public services, agriculture, health and education across the region if member states invest in the skills, infrastructure and data it needs.

- **Eswatini hosts regional push for practical AI policies** — Times of Eswatini, 16 September 2026 ESWATINI AFRICA

  Eswatini is hosting a three-day COMESA meeting, opened on 16 September 2026, to validate a draft study on AI and emerging technologies. It precedes work on a regional AI strategy, model policy guidelines and a model regulatory framework under the World Bank-funded IDEA programme.

Shared systems and infrastructure

Data Exchange · Digital Payments and Fintech

Data Exchange

CUSTOMS-TO-CUSTOMS DATA EXCHANGE ROADMAP

- **Five Southern African countries move to link customs data as trade corridors face pressure to cut delays** — Southern African Times, 2 September 2026 ZAMBIA MALAWI MOZAMBIQUE SOUTH AFRICA ZIMBABWE

  Customs administrations of Malawi, Mozambique, South Africa, Zambia and Zimbabwe adopted a roadmap and action plan for customs-to-customs data exchange at a meeting in Pretoria on 24-26 August 2026, hosted by the South African Revenue Service and convened by TradeMark Africa. The aim is to share trade data before consignments reach the border, building on existing Zambia-Malawi and Zambia-Zimbabwe links.

REGIONAL CUSTOMS-TO-CUSTOMS DATA EXCHANGE ROADMAP

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  Summarised under Data Exchange.

COMESA YELLOW CARD DIGITAL SALE AND VERIFICATION

- **Digital overhaul targets fraud in Sh3.5bn cross-border motor insurance market** — Business Daily (Nation Media Group), 13 October 2026 ZAMBIA EAST AFRICA

  COMESA's Yellow Card cross-border motor insurance scheme is piloting online sale of cover in Zambia in 2026 and expanding phone-based certificate verification, now used in eight countries, through data sharing between members, Business Daily reported on 13 October 2026. The scheme issued more than 340,000 cards in 2025, worth about US$27 million (Sh3.5 billion) in premiums.

Digital Payments and Fintech

SETTLEMENT CURRENCIES IN THE SADC-RTGS

- **Metical poderá ser usado em pagamentos na SADC a partir de Janeiro de 2027** — Times de Todos, 7 October 2026 MOZAMBIQUE

  Mozambique's central bank governor said the metical could be used for payments between Southern African countries from January 2027 through the regional real-time settlement system, which is hosted at South Africa's central bank.

Coordination and collaboration

Innovation ecosystem

Innovation ecosystem

INJINI SOUTHERN AFRICA AI EDTECH PROGRAMME

- **Injini lance un programme pour soutenir 12 start-up en Afrique australe** — wearetech.africa, 9 September 2026 SOUTH AFRICA

  The South African edtech accelerator Injini has launched an eight-month programme for twelve teams across Southern Africa building affordable AI tools adapted to local classrooms. The five strongest projects will receive seed funding at the end of it to develop their tools and test their impact with pupils and teachers; no amount is stated.

Capacity and inclusion

Training and skills · Digital divides

Training and skills

CRASA AND LINK CENTRE MEMORANDUM ON REGULATORY CAPACITY

- **CRASA and LINK Centre sign MoU** — LINK Centre - University of the Witwatersrand, 17 September 2026 SOUTH AFRICA

  The Southern African communications regulators' association and a university research centre signed a memorandum on regulatory capacity building, applied research and policy development, covering professional development programmes, short courses, masterclasses, policy dialogues and research across the ICT, postal, audio-visual, digital media and digitally enabled sectors. Activities are expressly subject to institutional processes, funding and separate project agreements.

Digital divides

COMESA REGIONAL DIGITAL INCLUSION STRATEGY

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  Summarised under Regional collaboration.

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